Analysis of Effective Tax Rates for NFL Players

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Executive Summary:

Compensation for professional athletes has grown dramatically over the past decade. The salary of the highest-paid players in the National Football League (NFL) has increased by more than five hundred percent in that period, a rate of growth unmatched by any other sector of the labor market. As total player compensation rises, so too does its significance as a contribution to public revenue through taxation. This paper examines the effective tax burden carried by the top one thousand NFL players by Average Per Year (APY), incorporating federal income tax, home-state income tax, and the so-called "jock tax" levied by states hosting away games. Our objective is to determine what share of each player's compensation is paid in taxes, and to identify which franchises carry the highest and lowest aggregate tax burdens.

Background:

Unlike most salaried employees, professional football players earn income across multiple states in a single season. The NFL formalizes this through what is commonly known as the jock tax, which requires athletes to file income taxes in each state where they perform. The taxable amount allocated to a given state is determined by the proportion of a player's "duty days" spent there relative to total duty days for the season. The NFL regular season comprises approximately 160 total duty days. For the purposes of this analysis, we assume each away game corresponds to approximately four duty days spent in the visiting state. This yields a simplified allocation of roughly 2.5% of annual salary as taxable income per road game:

$$\text{Taxable Income (away state)} \approx (4 / 160) \times \text{Total Salary} = 0.025 \times \text{Total Salary}$$

Federal income tax was computed using the IRS bracket schedule for a single filer with no dependents. State income tax rates were sourced from the Tax Foundation. For simplicity, local and county income taxes were excluded from all calculations, as these vary at a sub-state level and would require significantly more granular data collection.

Data /Method:

All data were collected through targeted web scraping using Python and the BeautifulSoup and pandas libraries. Player contract data was retrieved from overthecap.com by locating the sortable contract table, extracting headers and row data, and converting the results into a pandas DataFrame. Special characters, line breaks, and formatting artifacts were removed to enable numeric operations. The dataset was then sorted by APY and trimmed to the top 1,000 players to

focus on meaningful salary figures and avoid distortions from minimum-salary or practice-squad contracts. Away-game schedules for the 2025–26 season were scraped from ESPN's schedule page for all 32 teams. Because some teams played eight road games while others played nine, a conditional placeholder was inserted for eight-game teams to maintain a uniform DataFrame structure. Team names were then cross-referenced with a state-mapping table scraped from state.1keydata.com, which was standardized by retaining only the mascot portion of each team name to ensure consistent matching across datasets. State income tax rates were applied to the resulting away-state assignments, and federal rates were applied to full APY using a switch-case bracket structure.

Analysis:

With all three tax components combined federal, home-state, and jock tax; we will compute a total effective tax rate for each of the top 1,000 players. Multiplying this rate by each player's APY will yield an estimated annual tax liability in dollar terms. These figures will be visualized in two primary outputs: a bar chart displaying the top ten and bottom ten players by effective tax rate, and a ranked chart showing the average effective tax rate across all 32 NFL franchises. The team-level aggregation will reveal which franchises systematically expose their rosters to higher tax burdens, driven largely by home-state rates and divisional scheduling patterns; which benefit from operating in low or no income-tax states.

Assumptions:

Several simplifying assumptions were applied throughout this analysis. All players are treated as single filers claiming no dependents. Local income taxes are excluded. Each away game is assumed to generate exactly four duty days of taxable presence in that state, and playoff games are not included in duty-day calculations. Tax rates reflect the 2025–26 season; prior-season rates may differ. Finally, limiting the dataset to the top 1,000 players by APY means that minimum-salary players and short-term signings are not represented, though this population is of primary interest given the study's focus on high earners and their contribution to public revenue.

Data Sources:

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https://overthecap.com/contracts/buffalo-bills
https://smartasset.com/taxes/nfl-jock-taxes
https://overthecap.com
https://taxfoundation.org/data/all/state/state-income-tax-rates/
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